

Minimum Extendable Fano Projections and the Five-Cycle Double Cover Conjecture

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Resolution status. The five-cycle double cover conjecture remains unresolved. This note proves an exchange theorem and an exact finite census, and isolates a new candidate selection principle. It proves neither the conjecture nor its negation.

Abstract

Hušek and Šámal recently expressed the five-cycle double cover conjecture as the problem of selecting a nowhere-zero $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ -flow with a component-parity property. We study the support h of one binary coordinate of such a flow. Call h *extendable* if it occurs as a coordinate of some nowhere-zero $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ -flow.

We prove a simultaneous exchange theorem for a minimum-cardinality extendable projection. Write the flow as $f = (h, s)$, with $s : E \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2^2$, and partition h into the four affine value classes $M_c = \{e \in h : s(e) = c\}$. For every c , the projection h is a minimum-cardinality binary cycle containing M_c . Equivalently, every binary cycle C avoiding M_c satisfies

$$|C \cap h| \leq |C - h|.$$

Thus every circuit component of h contains all four affine colours, and every support-shortening cycle meets all four classes. The proof is the addition of the Fano value $(1, c)$ along C .

We then perform an exact census of all 41,301 connected simple cubic graphs of order 18. Among the 39,866 bridgeless graphs, exactly 179 are not Tait-colourable. Full cycle-space enumeration shows that every minimum-cardinality extendable projection of every one of these 179 graphs has a clean lift satisfying the Hušek–Šámal component parity condition. The canonical record digest is 82b01cc2f01d4f50f7745f4bdb1b3dc46ade798d452a9d4f11d4a91d738a7834.

The universal statement suggested by this computation is recorded as an open conjecture. The missing step is to derive a colour-avoiding strict exchange from a rainbow-odd component, possibly after support-neutral recolouring. We make no claim of a FiveCDC resolution or of priority for the flow formulation.

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1 Status, conventions, and contribution boundary

A binary cycle of a graph is an Eulerian edge set; it may be empty or disconnected. A k -cycle double cover is an indexed family of k binary cycles in which every edge occurs exactly twice. Empty members may be appended, so “at most five” and “five, allowing empty members” are equivalent. The five-cycle double cover conjecture, attributed to Celmins and Preissmann, asserts that every bridgeless graph has such a cover with at most five members [1, 4].

We work with the cubic flow formulation in [3, Conjecture 3.19]. No general-to-cubic reduction is proved in this note. All theoretical statements below apply to finite loopless cubic multigraphs unless “simple” is stated. Parallel edges are distinct edge objects. A loop would contribute twice to vertex degree; loops are excluded here to keep the cut notation literal. The finite census is restricted to simple graphs.

Hušek and Šámal prove that the cubic FiveCDC problem is equivalent to selecting a nowhere-zero $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ -flow with an additional parity condition [3, Theorem 3.16 and Conjecture 3.19]. Their criterion is related to the prescribed-cycle formulation of Hoffmann-Ostenhof [2]. We claim no novelty or priority for either formulation.

The contribution of this note is narrower:

1. a minimum-support exchange theorem, with a complete proof;
2. elementary consequences for four simultaneous shortest T -joins;
3. a reproducible exhaustive order-18 census; and
4. a precise conjectural step that would turn this route into a proof.

The last item is open.

2 Extendable and clean Fano projections

Let $G = (V, E)$ be a loopless cubic graph and put $K = \mathbb{F}_2^2$. Write a three-bit flow as

$$f = (h, s) : E \longrightarrow \mathbb{F}_2 \times K, \quad (1)$$

where $h : E \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2$ and $s : E \rightarrow K$ are flows. We identify a binary flow with its support.

Definition 2.1. A nonzero binary cycle h is *extendable* if there is a flow $s : E \rightarrow K$ for which $f = (h, s)$ is nowhere zero.

Writing $s = (p, q)$, extendability has the following elementary form:

$$E - h \subseteq p \cup q, \quad (2)$$

where p and q are binary cycles. Indeed, an edge of $E - h$ has first coordinate zero and therefore needs a nonzero low coordinate.

Fix an extension $f = (h, s)$. For $c \in K$, put

$$M_c = \{e \in h : s(e) = c\}. \quad (3)$$

Proposition 2.2. *Every M_c is a matching, and the four sets M_c partition h .*

Proof. The partition statement is immediate. If two edges incident with a cubic vertex both had flow value $(1, c)$, their sum would be zero and flow conservation would force the third incident edge to have value zero, contrary to nowhere-zerosness. $\square$

Let W be a component of the spanning subgraph $(V, E - h)$. Every edge of $\delta(W)$ belongs to h . If

$$n_c(W) = |\delta(W) \cap M_c| \pmod{2},$$

then cut conservation for the first coordinate and the two low coordinates gives

$$\sum_{c \in K} n_c(W) = 0, \quad \sum_{c \in K} n_c(W)c = 0. \quad (4)$$

The 3×4 binary matrix in (4) has one-dimensional kernel, generated by the all-ones vector. Hence the four parities $n_c(W)$ are equal.

Definition 2.3. An extension is *clean* if $n_c(W) = 0$ for every component W of $(V, E - h)$, for one, and hence every, $c \in K$. A projection h is *cleanable* if it has a clean extension. A component with all four parities equal to one is *rainbow-odd*.

If $s = (p, q)$, the class M_{11} on $\delta(W)$ is $\delta(W) \cap p \cap q$. Thus cleanability is exactly the existence of binary cycles p, q satisfying (2) and

$$|\delta(W) \cap p \cap q| \equiv 0 \pmod{2} \quad (5)$$

for every component W of $(V, E - h)$. By [3, Theorem 3.16], existence of such an h is equivalent to the cubic FiveCDC assertion. In the Tait-colourable case one may take $h = \emptyset$ and a nowhere-zero K -flow.

3 The minimum-projection exchange theorem

Assume now that G is not Tait-colourable, so an extendable projection cannot be empty. Choose h of minimum cardinality among all extendable projections, and fix any extension $f = (h, s)$.

Theorem 3.1 (minimum-projection exchange). *For every $c \in K$ and every binary cycle C with $C \cap M_c = \emptyset$,*

$$|C \cap h| \leq |C - h|. \quad (6)$$

Equivalently, h is a minimum-cardinality binary cycle containing M_c , simultaneously for all four $c \in K$.

Proof. Fix $c \in K$, put $t = (1, c)$, and add t to the flow value on every edge of C :

$$f'(e) = \begin{cases} f(e) + t, & e \in C, \\ f(e), & e \notin C. \end{cases} \quad (7)$$

Since C is a binary cycle, the added function is a flow. The only edges that could become zero in (7) are those whose old value was t , and these are exactly the edges of M_c . The hypothesis $C \cap M_c = \emptyset$ therefore makes f' nowhere zero.

The first coordinate of f' is $h \triangle C$. This is another extendable projection, so minimality gives

$$|h| \leq |h \triangle C| = |h| + |C - h| - |C \cap h|.$$

This is (6).

For the equivalent statement, rebase the low coordinates by replacing s with the flow $s + ch$. Its exact zero set is M_c : outside h , the low value was already nonzero, while on h it vanishes exactly when $s(e) = c$.

Let h' be any binary cycle containing M_c . The flow $(h', s + ch)$ is nowhere zero. On an edge outside h' , its low value is nonzero because every zero lies in $M_c \subseteq h'$; on an edge of h' , its first coordinate is one. Thus h' is extendable, and $|h| \leq |h'|$.

Conversely, if $C \cap M_c = \emptyset$, then $h \triangle C$ contains M_c . Applying the minimum-containing property to $h \triangle C$ recovers (6). $\square$

3.1 Shortest joins and four-colour consequences

Let T_c be the set of endpoints of M_c . Removing M_c from a binary cycle containing M_c produces a T_c -join in $G - M_c$, and adjoining M_c reverses the correspondence. Therefore Theorem 3.1 has the following form.

Corollary 3.2. *For every $c \in K$, the edge set*

$$J_c = h - M_c$$

is a shortest T_c -join in $G - M_c$.

This is not the already-refuted principle that a cardinality-minimum exact-zero matching must extend to a FiveCDC certificate. Here the objective is the cardinality of the whole binary cycle $M_c \cup J_c$, and the same projection is optimal after all four affine rebases.

Corollary 3.3 (flow-resistance bound). *Let $r_f(G)$ be the minimum number of zero edges in an $\mathbb{F}_2^2$ -flow on G . Every extendable projection satisfies*

$$|h| \geq 4r_f(G). \tag{8}$$

Proof. For each c , the rebased low flow $s + ch$ has exact zero set M_c . Hence $|M_c| \geq r_f(G)$. The four M_c 's partition h . $\square$

Corollary 3.4 (four-colour circuits). *Every circuit component of h contains at least one edge of each of the four sets M_c .*

Proof. If a circuit component D omitted M_c , then D would be a binary cycle avoiding M_c , but $|D \cap h| = |D| > |D - h| = 0$, contrary to (6). $\square$

Corollary 3.5 (rainbow shortcut). *Every binary cycle C satisfying $|C \cap h| > |C - h|$ meets all four sets M_c .*

Proof. If C omitted one class M_c , it would contradict (6). $\square$

4 The exact missing step

Theorem 3.1 suggests the following selection principle.

Conjecture 4.1 (minimum extendable projection). Every bridgeless cubic graph has a minimum-cardinality extendable projection that is cleanable.

The stronger statement that every minimum projection is cleanable also survives the finite census in Section 5, but it is not needed. Conjecture 4.1, together with the Hušek–Šámal equivalence, would imply the cubic FiveCDC conjecture.

Suppose a minimum projection h is not cleanable. Every extension then has a rainbow-odd component W of $G - h$, so all four M_c 's cross $\delta(W)$ oddly. A direct proof of Conjecture 4.1 would need to derive either

1. a binary cycle C avoiding some M_c and satisfying $|C \cap h| > |C - h|$, contradicting Theorem 3.1;
or
2. a sequence of support-neutral low-coordinate recolourings followed by such a strict exchange.

The second possibility cannot currently be discarded. Small exact examples have four disjoint colour classes meeting every immediately component-reducing cycle, while a support-preserving recolouring escapes the trap. Other examples show that a fixed nowhere-zero Fano flow can have all seven of its functional projections dirty. These are proof-strategy obstructions, not FiveCDC counterexamples. They rule out an argument that fixes an arbitrary initial flow or assumes one elementary switch always suffices.

The unresolved human proof obligation is precise: from a rainbow-odd component of an *uncleanable globally minimum-support projection*, derive a negative colour-avoiding cycle after allowable neutral recolouring, using the four simultaneous shortest- T_c -join inequalities of Corollary 3.2. No proof of this statement is given here.

5 Exact order-18 census

5.1 Method

The accompanying checker uses canonical generation rather than sampling. For order 18, the command

```
geng -cq -d3 -D3 18
```

generates every connected simple cubic graph once. The checker then:

1. tests bridgelessness by deleting every edge and checking connectivity;
2. tests Tait colourability by exhaustive backtracking;
3. enumerates the entire binary cycle space;
4. processes nonzero projections h by increasing cardinality;
5. quotients pairs of cycles (p, q) by their exact semantic state $(p \cup q, p \cap q)$;
6. tests extendability by $E - h \subseteq p \cup q$; and
7. computes the components of $G - h$ and tests (5) on every component.

For a connected cubic graph of order 18, the binary cycle-space dimension is

$$|E| - |V| + 1 = 27 - 18 + 1 = 10.$$

Thus all $2^{10} = 1024$ binary cycles are enumerated. Equal union/intersection pairs have exactly the same coverage and component parity behaviour, so the semantic quotient loses no information. No snark or cyclic-connectivity reduction is used.

5.2 Results and reproducibility

class	count
connected simple cubic graphs	41,301
bridgeless graphs	39,866
bridgeless non-Tait graphs	179

Table 1: Complete order-18 population.

Every minimum-cardinality extendable projection of every one of the 179 non-Tait graphs is cleanable. The minimum-size histogram is

$$5 : 166, \quad 6 : 11, \quad 7 : 1, \quad 8 : 1.$$

The checker hashes, in canonical graph order, the graph6 string, minimum size, number of minimum extendable projections, and number of cleanable minimum projections. The resulting SHA-256 is

82b01cc2f01d4f50f7745f4bdb1b3dc46ade798d452a9d4f11d4a91d738a7834.

From the project root, run:

```
python3 scratch/check_husek_samal_minimum_projection_frontier.py \
--order 18
```

The checker requires Python, the sibling cycle-space module `scratch/search_fano_all_bad_projection_subspaces.py`, and nauty `geng` on PATH. It has no SAT solver, network, or non-standard Python-package dependency. The relevant source hashes are

```
frontier checker:
37e972782863c7a9506f6d339159ddaca3865363107704f86365c1a9b77a30c3
cycle-space module:
7e5ea2599e7533f041ea88de5c6f5c7a3bf542cedc33d78728439d43ce8861e8
```

This is a finite theorem. It is evidence for Conjecture 4.1, not a proof of it.

6 Discussion

The exchange theorem converts global support minimality into four ordinary geodesic conditions: one shortest join for each affine value class. The useful feature is simultaneity. A cycle that would shorten the projection is allowed to be blocked by one colour, but Corollary 3.5 forces it to be blocked by all four. Likewise, disconnected projections are severely constrained because every circuit component must contain every colour.

What is not yet understood is how the common rainbow-odd cut interacts with the four shortest-join duals. A publishable resolution would need either a cut/cycle contradiction, a neutral-reconfiguration theorem, or an exact counterexample to Conjecture 4.1. Until one of those is supplied, the correct status is a frontier result.

AI-use and verification disclosure

This research route, proof draft, checker, computation, and exposition were developed by OpenAI Codex agents under Atharva Vaidya’s direction. The minimum-projection exchange proof is displayed in full so that it can be checked without trusting an AI system. The order-18 result is reproducible from canonical generation and exhaustive cycle-space enumeration; it is still a computational result and should be independently rerun.

Hušek and Šámal’s flow criterion and Hoffmann-Ostenhof’s matching/join formulation are prior work. This draft makes no claim of a FiveCDC resolution and no priority claim for the minimum-projection viewpoint pending expert literature review. Before public submission, a human graph theorist should check the proof line by line, rerun the census in a clean environment, audit the bibliography, and decide authorship and venue policy under the applicable AI-disclosure rules.

References

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- [2] Arthur Hoffmann-Ostenhof. A note on 5-cycle double covers. *Graphs and Combinatorics*, 29:977–979, 2013.
- [3] Radek Hušek and Robert Šámal. Exponentially many circuit double covers, 2026. Version 1, submitted July 27, 2026.
- [4] Myriam Preissmann. *Sur les colorations des arêtes des graphes cubiques*. PhD thesis, Université de Grenoble, 1981.